Gmail

Tom Piccolo <tompiccolo50@gmail.com>

Fwd: A further email regarding the significance of GCSE and A Level attainment- I would hope to hear a response

1 message

Steve Guire <steveguire123@outlook.com>
To: "tompiccolo50@gmail.com" <tompiccolo50@gmail.com>

2 May 2024 at 10:42

Sent from my iPhone

Begin forwarded message:

From: Anne Carpenter <a.carpenter@qaa.ac.uk>
Date: 2 May 2024 at 11:36:40 BST
To: Steve Guire <steveguire123@outlook.com>
Subject: RE: A further email regarding the significance of GCSE and A Level attainment- I would hope to hear a response

Dear Steve,

Thank you for your email. We cannot comment on matters relating to individual students or providers, but we can say that we have qualification descriptors in the UK, within the Frameworks for Higher Education Qualifications of UK Degree-Awarding Bodies. These descriptors are a UK-wide standard for courses at all levels of higher education. All providers in England are required by the Office for Students (the HE regulator in England) to meet these descriptors as a minimum, but are free to go above and beyond them in terms of the content, complexity, academic stretch etc of the courses they offer. Indeed this will happen as the descriptors are set at the 3rd-class degree level, and individual achievement will look different at 2:2, 2:1 and 1st classifications.

We also publish Subject Benchmark Standards which, again, describe the minimum content/competence levels the sector expects from graduates in particular subjects. The SBSs are voluntary, and providers are free to go beyond them.

We hope this helps.

Kind Regards,

Anne

Anne Carpenter

Membership Coordinator

The Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education

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From: Steve Guire <steveguire123@outlook.com>
Sent: 25 April 2024 17:19
To: Anne Carpenter <a.carpenter@qaa.ac.uk>
Subject: A further email regarding the significance of GCSE and A Level attainment- I would hope to hear a response

Hello

I hope you are doing well.

I wanted to gain some insight into the following questions.

First of all, I have been told that Russell Group universities set high tariffs as their courses are actually academically harder and more challenging than those of other universities.

This is what the Russell Group themselves told me. They told me that the reason they ask for A*AA in their STEM subjects is because the content and assessment in their STEM courses make those courses unsuitable for candidates with, say, BCC. Of those with BCC who get into Russell Group universities via Clearing, 54% gain a 2:2 or below.

So, therefore, on that basis, for a given subject at university, like Chemistry, whose entry requirements range from C's to A*'s, there is a wide spectrum of ability.

Therefore, this means that not all university undergraduate students would necessarily be able to successfully complete the attached questions, which are grade 9 questions targeted at the most able GCSE Chemistry students. As not all students are operating at that level, or the A* level at A Level.

Therefore is the following reasoning invalid:

You can do an MChem at the University of Lincoln. It asks for BCC at A Level with a grade C in Chemistry. However, according to the QAA:

Study at master's level requires higher level skills, with students expected to achieve according to the descriptor for a higher education qualification at Level 7 on the FHEQ

That above statement invalidates the statement that the Russell Group themselves told me. The above statement essentially acts to generalise every single masters degree.

It implies that everyone, even those with C's at A Level in Chemistry entering a fairly low tier university are all:

Excessively exceeding the A* in Chemistry A Level

- A Levels mean nothing

Excessively exceeding the 9 in GCSE Chemistry

➔ GCSE's mean nothing.

So Russell Group universities "selecting for high attaining students at A Level in STEM subjects" for STEM courses means absolutely nothing, at all, as all university undergraduates are equivalent.

Essentially, by the end of tertiary education in STEM fields, everyone is working at the standard of all A*'s or all 9's in those subjects. They all end up exactly the same.

So, high entry requirements are pointless and meaningless as everyone gets to the same level.

Is the above reasoning true? It vehemently goes against what the CEO of the Russell Group told me.

To give an example related to Chemistry A Level:

My friend could answer questions that only the top 7-9% of candidates nationally could answer in A Level Chemistry.

The percentage of candidates who got all the highest demand questions correct was 1.06%. My friend was in that statistic.

But does that not mean anything, as now, suddenly, everyone is in that statistic? Everyone is at the same level? Everyone who does STEM is suddenly in the top 1% of A Level ability?

Similarly, could any STEM undergraduate get all of the grade 8-9 GCSE questions completely correct as everyone, regardless of their prior grades, is on the same incredibly high level? The attached questions are all grade 9 questions targeted at the most able GCSE Chemistry students.

Meaning that A Levels and GCSE grades should not matter for university progression. But they really do. Research has shown that they do.

Do you see my point? If they didn't matter, everyone would be performing above the highest grades at both GCSE and A Level so their prior grades wouldn't matter.

But they do. This implies that not everyone is actually performing at the same level in a given subject at undergraduate level as their prior attainment varies massively.

The very fact that you have people with BCC doing better at lower tariff institutions than higher tariff institutions (majority of BCC students get a 2:2 or below at high tariff institutions) implies that there are indeed disparities between groups.

In today's world, you have:

Students with borderline grade 7's at GCSE chemistry and scraping C's at A level

Students with extremely high grade 9's in all their GCSE sciences and extremely high A* grades at A Level

Is there really no difference between those two groups at undergraduate level...?

Regards,
Steve

Sent from Outlook for iOS

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